

Past perfect tense: Roberta's terrible day

Let's read this story about a woman called Roberta. She's had a terrible day.

Roberta's story

I had a terrible day today. It started badly and just got worse.

I woke up late because I'd forgotten to set my alarm clock. Because I was late, I ran to the train station but when I got there I realised I hadn't brought my **season ticket**. I missed my train.

By the time I arrived at work, the staff meeting had already started. I really wanted to finish work at the usual time of 5pm because I wanted to see my favourite band at a concert. But I couldn't leave on time because I hadn't completed the report my boss had asked for.

I left work late - and by the time I arrived at the concert **venue**, the band had already finished playing. I **wept** like a child.

season ticket - a ticket that can be used many times over a long period

concert - a music show

venue - the place where something happens, like a meeting or show

wept - cried

Answer the questions about Roberta's story

1. *"It started badly and just got worse." What happened first?*

A The day started badly

B The day got worse

2. *"I woke up late because I'd forgotten to set my alarm clock." What happened first?*

A Roberta forgot to set her alarm clock

B Roberta woke up

3. *"By the time I arrived at work, the staff meeting had already started." What happened first?*

A She arrived at work

B The staff meeting started

4. *"But couldn't leave on time because I hadn't completed the report my boss had asked for." What happened first?*

A The clock struck 5pm

B She completed her report

5. *"I ran to the train station but when I got there I realised I hadn't brought my season ticket." Which order of events is correct?*

A 1) She ran to the station 2) She realised that her ticket was still at home 3) She left home without her ticket

B 1) She left home without her ticket 2) She ran to the station 3) She realised that her ticket was still at home

C 1) She ran to the station 2) She forgot her ticket at home 3) She realised that her ticket was still at home

6. *"...by the time I arrived at the concert venue, the band had already finished playing. I wept like a child." Which order of events is correct?*

A 1) She arrived at the concert venue 2) The band stopped playing 3) She cried

B 1) The band stopped playing 2) She arrived at the concert venue 3) She cried

C 1) She cried 2) She arrived at the concert venue 3) The band stopped playing

Meaning and use:

When I arrived home, my son had already made an enormous carrot cake.

What happened **first**: my son made a cake

What happened **second**: I arrived

We use the **past perfect part** of the sentence to show which event happened first (and the past simple to say what happened second):

We can also change the order of events in the sentence, and still show what happened first.

My son had made an enormous carrot cake when I arrived home.

Form

The past perfect is made with **subject + had/hadn't + past participle**.